

its members, the soprano Isobel Harrison. The couple married in 1901; their daughter, Imogen, later become a prominent musician in her own right.



THAXTED

Holst had a country home in the picturesque village of Thaxted in northwest Essex. In 1916, he started a music festival at the village's magnificent medieval church of St. John, whose elegant spire is visible here rising above the Essex landscape.

Diverse influences

Holst greatly admired Wagner's advanced harmonic style but was also attracted to English folk music—twin enthusiasms he shared with Vaughan Williams. A symphony subtitled “The Cotswolds,” followed by A Somerset Rhapsody, drew on both areas of interest. Holst was also intrigued by Indian mythology, which inspired a set of Choral Hymns from the Hindu sacred text the Rig Veda and the chamber opera Savitri, based on a story from the Sanskrit epic Mahabharata. An interest in astrology steered him toward the idea of an orchestral work based on seven of the planets in Earth's solar system. He began work on The Planets in